Individual Intensive Interviews of Car-Dependent Resident's Physical Mobility and Access to Community Storytelling Networks: Implications for Civic Engagement Opportunities

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Abstract

While online platforms expand civic engagement channels, offline participation remains critical to democracy. Community places act as grounds for conversations between strangers of differing perspectives and ideologies, allowing for a diverse exchange of ideas within the public square. This study examines how mobility infrastructure shapes citizens' access to local communication environments, which in turn conditions civic and political engagement. Drawing on Communication Infrastructure Theory, we conceptualize physical mobility as a spatial context influencing one's integration within the neighborhood information ecology. This study uses the intensive individual interview method, and the responses through convenience sampling. This study is specifically interested in investigating the ways in which living in an area which restricts ones method of travel to being dependent on a car shapes their social network. The storytelling network, made up of interpersonal conversations, local organizations and local media, and digital channels allows for residents to share information about civic matters and neighborhood life. Access to physical locations can increase a resident's level of integration within these channels. My research question is in two parts, (a) To what extent do car-dependent communities (IV) inhibit residents' ability to access their social networks (DV)? To what extent do car-dependent environments (IV) influence the mode of communication (DV), whether face-to-face or by mediated contact? This study hypothesizes that researchers will find that residents who live in environments which force them to have to depend on a car for transportation will have restricted opportunities for integration within this storytelling neighborhood network, and therefore may have to use digital means to access social spaces as an alternative coping mechanism due to the lack of physical spaces for community communication and information channels.

Communication scholars have increasingly examined how place-based communication processes shape civic engagement and collective action. Drawing on Communication Infrastructure Theory (CIT; Kim & Ball-Rokeach, 2006), this study introduces physical mobility as a key contextual factor shaping residents' connectedness to neighborhood communication environments through transportation systems, pedestrian infrastructure, and spatial connectivity (Cheng & Chen, 2015). This study extends Communication Infrastructure Theory by introducing physical mobility as a structural condition shaping residents' access to neighborhood communication environments and, in turn, their opportunities for civic engagement. Rather than treating mobility as a matter of transportation alone, the study conceptualizes it as part of the democratic communication environment through which residents encounter local information, interact with others, and connect to community organizations (Cheng & Chen, 2015). In this case, physical mobility may influence not only movement through space but also integration into storytelling networks. Because storytelling networks are spatially embedded, mobility conditions shape residents' opportunities to encounter others and exchange information relevant to civic participation (Üblacker et al., 2024; Phillips et al., 2021). Prior CIT research has examined commuting time as an individual-level constraint (Jung & Kim, 2018), but this study conceptualizes physical mobility as a key CAC factor, in addition to shifting focus to the broader mobility infrastructures structuring opportunities for local interaction. This study also introduces digital local platforms as an additional level of integration to the storytelling network, in some

cases where physical social opportunities lack acting as an alternative coping mechanism for accessing channels communication and information within the local neighborhood. This study intends to investigate the question, does physical mobility condition the relationship between storytelling networks and neighborhood belonging? This study utilizes a qualitative design and the method of intensive individual interviews to explore why people feel inhibited or empowered by their physical mobility to have opportunities for social connection.

Literature Review

In-Depth Summary

Ball-Rokeach et al. (2001) demonstrated that neighborhood storytelling networks, which are made up of an integration of everyday interpersonal conversations, local media, and community organizations provide residents with information and social ties that boost belonging and civic participation (Kim & Ball-Rokeach, 2006; Nah et al., 2021). The concept of Integrated Connectedness to Storytelling Networks (ICSN) captures how embedded a resident is across these channels. The more connected residents are, the more access they have to community information and the more embedded they become in the neighborhood's information ecosystem, which in turn enables civic engagement and collective action (Kim & Ball-Rokeach, 2006; Nah et al., 2021). Using survey data from multiple Los Angeles neighborhoods, the study measured residents' communication patterns and their sense of belonging. People who were connected across more storytelling channels reported stronger belonging than those with weaker ties. Concluding that neighborhoods do not only serve as geographic locations but as physical borders for communication networks which create shared meaning and attachment to place through everyday storytelling. This framework also introduced the Communication Action Context (CAC), or the neighborhood conditions, such as public spaces, residential stability, and ethnic diversity that shape how residents integrate into local networks (Kim & Ball-Rokeach, 2006; Kim et al., 2014). This study laid the theoretical groundwork for CIT and the ICSN concept that remains central to understanding how communication drives civic engagement and community attachment.

Nah, Kwon, Liu, and McNealy (2021) extended CIT by asking how social media fits alongside traditional neighborhood storytelling networks. Using a quantitative survey, they measured ICSN, social media use, and both online and offline civic participation across diverse U.S. communities. Stronger storytelling network connectedness predicted higher civic engagement, and social media amplified that relationship by opening up more opportunities for local communication and information sharing. Rather than replacing face-to-face interaction, digital media acted as an additional storytelling resource that complemented interpersonal communication, local media, and community organizations. Within CIT, digital platforms are emerging storytelling agents, as they extend community communication and interaction (Nah et al., 2021). Earlier research had already shown that locality-oriented internet and mobile use strengthens the link between ICSN and civic participation (Nah & Yamamoto, 2017), and this

study confirmed that pattern holds for social media too. This study demonstrates that digital platforms are now woven into neighborhood communication systems, which sets up the question of whether their influence changes under different physical mobility conditions.

Definitions

Communication Infrastructure Theory explains how communities produce a shared sense of belonging with their neighborhoods through interconnected storytelling networks, made up of resident's interpersonal relationships, local media, and community organizations all exchange information about civic matters and neighborhood life. Integrated Connectedness to Storytelling Networks (ICSN) captures the degree to which a resident is embedded within these channels (Kim & Ball-Rokeach, 2006). The higher the level of embeddedness the higher the amount of information a resident is receiving through these channels. This embeddedness within a storytelling network also shapes a resident's place attachment, which is the emotional and functional bonds people develop with meaningful places, usually measured through place identity and place dependence (Williams & Vaske, 2003), and civic engagement, which is residents' participation in activities meant to improve or influence their communities. Additionally, a resident's sense of community measures belonging, mutual influence, shared needs, and emotional connection among members. Finally, physical mobility is not limited to the ability to travel, it also includes features of the built environment such as pedestrian infrastructure, neighborhood connectivity, and public transit access that shape opportunities for social interaction and engagement with storytelling networks (Cheng & Chen, 2015). Together, these concepts provide the foundation for examining whether mobility conditions change how digital media relates to place attachment and civic engagement.

Common Research Methods

Previous studies on how mobility can inhibit or benefit quality of life have utilized quantitative cross-sectional survey designs. Participants are asked to fill out standardized questionnaires measuring things like place attachment or sense of community, with questions about how they use parks, neighborhoods, transit, or community spaces. Researchers typically recruit residents through area-based sampling, mailed surveys, on-site intercepts, or random household sampling across multiple neighborhoods. This lets them compare people in different physical environments and identify statistical relationships between environmental conditions and community outcomes. Although the cross-sectional survey design can show association, this design cannot establish causation.

Another common feature is the use of validated multi-item scales. Place attachment is usually measured with adaptations of Williams and Vaske's (2003) scales, often separating items such as place identity from place dependence. Sense of community typically gets measured with versions of the Sense of Community Index or similar validated instruments. Researchers

compare these measures across different neighborhood designs, pedestrian environments, parks, or transit settings using regression and other statistical techniques. Although standardized measures improve reliability, direct comparisons are often made harder by the fact that researchers operationalize physical environments differently from one another.

Common Findings

The most consistent finding across CIT research is that stronger storytelling networks predict greater civic engagement. Residents more integrated into interpersonal communication, local media, and community organizations participate more, allowing these networks to provide information, social support, and opportunities to act collectively (Kim & Ball-Rokeach, 2006; Nah et al., 2021; Nah & Yamamoto, 2017). More recent work shows digital media extends these networks rather than replacing them, adding new channels for local communication and civic participation (Kwon et al., 2020; Nah et al., 2026).

Another consistent finding is that neighborhood design provides uplifting or hindering resident's quality of life. Environments that support walking and social interaction including parks, pedestrian-friendly streets, good transit strengthen emotional bonds of residents to their neighborhood and increase belonging (Buttazzoni & Irwin, 2025; Williams & Vaske, 2003; Cheng & Chen, 2015). Poorly connected environments with limited interaction opportunities are linked to weaker place attachment and less community engagement. The built environment acts as a moderator shaping decisions of resident's daily lives, seductively directing where social relationships and community identities develop.

Few studies directly examine physical mobility within CIT, but several lines of research suggest mobility conditions shape community interaction. Storytelling networks are spatially embedded, so residents' ability to encounter neighbors, organizations, and local information depends on the mobility opportunities the built environment provides (Phillips et al., 2021; Üblacker et al., 2024). CIT already accounts for these neighborhood characteristics through the Communication Action Context, and transportation research confirms that pedestrian infrastructure, transit access, and connectivity influence perceived mobility and interaction opportunities (Cheng & Chen, 2015). Collectively, this points to physical mobility as a factor that could shape how residents become embedded in storytelling networks and, in turn, how digital media contributes to place attachment and civic engagement.

Summary and Critique

With all this in consideration, the literature suggests that digital media's civic role depends on neighborhood mobility conditions. When mobility is limited, digital platforms may become alternative spaces for connection and information exchange, creating different pathways into civic engagement depending on local context (Aguiléra et al., 2012; Nah et al., 2021). Research in disadvantaged neighborhoods shows that when safe physical gathering places are

scarce and people stay indoors to avoid risks, social media can function as a "digital third space" that supports connectedness and community interaction (Stevens et al., 2016). My study extends this idea beyond safety as a mobility constraint and looks specifically at how car-dependent environments shape the relationship between mobility and place attachment.

The literature clearly shows that communication networks, digital media, and neighborhood environments all contribute to civic engagement and place attachment. CIT explains how storytelling networks foster participation, while environmental psychology and urban planning research show that pedestrian-friendly environments strengthen place attachment and sense of community. However, these two concepts have developed parallel to one another within their respective fields. CIT research focuses on communication processes, whereas mobility research focuses on the built environment with little attention to digital media. As a result, not much is known about whether physical mobility conditions actually moderate the relationship between digital media use, place attachment, and civic engagement. My proposed study bridges this gap by integrating CIT with mobility and built environment research. Rather than treating digital media and physical mobility as separate, this study conceptualizes mobility as a key part of the Communication Action Context, one that may strengthen or weaken how digital media connects to place attachment and civic engagement. By measuring pedestrian infrastructure, neighborhood connectivity, and transit access alongside digital media use, this study offers a fuller picture of how communication and physical environments work together to shape community life.

Research Design

Overview

This study uses individual intensive interviews to examine how car-dependent infrastructure affects community network density. Interviews afford the opportunity for the interviewee to ask directly about the informant's experiences, motivations, and attitudes, details which can be difficult to capture through observation alone (Berger, 2011, p. 138). Because the research question concerns how infrastructure shapes the experience of making community connections, interviews are a good fit, because they let informants describe the world they live in and how mobility shapes their daily interactions. The method requires building rapport and trust, which does require increased invested time and energy, but yields richer, more personal data than surveys might provide (Week 9 Lecture).

Method Comparison

Previous studies have commonly used cross-sectional surveys to quantify relationships between built environment characteristics and community outcomes. These surveys are effective

for establishing correlation. For example, more mobility infrastructure is linked to stronger community outcomes. However, these quantitative surveys are less suited for explaining why that relationship exists. This study proposes using intensive interviews to explore causation by talking directly with people who live in car-dependent environments and understanding how their day-to-day mobility shapes their community networks. The trade-off is that qualitative data takes longer to collect and analyze than survey data.

Modality

This study uses in-person interviews. This modality allows me to observe not just what informants say but also their facial expressions, tone, and gestures, creating a more holistic interpretation of the data (Berger, 2011, p. 139). In-person interaction also makes it easier to establish the rapport and trust needed for a conversational, partnership-style interview rather than an interrogation (Week 9 Lecture).

Procedures

Sampling and Recruitment

This study uses convenience sampling, as the researcher is conducting their interviews from a car-dependent setting, this leads to easy access to recruiting peers and neighbors who share this setting. The familiarity of this environment aids in the researcher being able to develop relevant questions and understand informants' experiences. However, this also introduces bias, as the sample will not be representative of other communication action contexts. That is acceptable because the goal is not to re-establish a known correlation but to explore causation of how the experience of limited mobility infrastructure shapes community connections.

This study will recruit potential interviews by sending a personal message to potential respondents, as well as using social media platforms as a tool to access the researcher’s community network. The message sent to potential respondents is included below.

"Hello, this is Michelle Parson. I hope all is well! I am taking a summer class at MSU and am hosting a study looking into how mobility or how easy it is to get around affects community relationships! If you or anyone you may know is interested in participating in a 20–40 minute interview about your experiences living in a place with limited mobility, or which is prioritizing automobility, please feel free to reach me to set up a time which will work for you to meet! I am hosting in-person interviews the week of July 20th through the end of the month. My phone number is (248)600-6914. Thank you for your time and energy. I am sending my well wishes!:)"

This message will be sent via iMessage and posted as a temporary 24-hour listing on Instagram and Facebook to reach my convenience sample from the nearby car-dependent community. I will send the message out in several tiered rounds of informants, labeled from most to least likely to be incentivized to participate. Interviewees will willingly participate because the convenience sample is drawn from my existing network of peers and local community members. Many of these individuals already have some degree of established relationship with me or with someone in my network. This existing rapport helps build trust and makes the interview feel more like a conversation between caring friends, which incentivizes careful and honest sharing.

Implementation

I will post the recruitment message on my social media accounts, which are locally embedded, meaning the majority of my network consists of neighbors and community members who also experience the car-dependent environment I am studying. I will also reach out via text message to my interpersonal contacts with the same message. I will track who responds and schedule interview appointments at their convenience during the week of July 20th through the end of the month. I will book a group study room at my local library to host the in-person interviews in a comfortable, secure, recordable setting. I will know I have reached the saturation point when interviewees begin to produce little to no new information about the experience of living in a car-dependent community and how it affects their relationships with their community networks. If I have trouble recruiting enough interviewees, I have several tiers of contacts available to reach out to beyond my first round of most-likely-to-respond informants. I will cycle through this network and politely ask for help spreading the word to find additional informants for an in-person individual intensive interview.

Walk-Through

The first step is to post the recruitment messages. After several rounds the researcher will have collected enough informants to interview a first round. The researcher will have to reach out to schedule individual times and dates to meet in-person for the 30-40 minute intensive individual interview. The researcher and interviewee will meet 5 minutes prior to the agreed upon time and date to ensure all technicalities go smoothly. The interviewer proceeds to establish trust and empathy between themselves and the interviewee, by asking with simple questions and some small talk. After some patience and some conversation has been initiated, the interviewer may begin with the first round of questions being answered, the researcher proceeds to ask several follow-up questions pertaining to what peaked their interest in the respondent's answers to the first round of questions. The interview continues until all ends have been followed and there is no more information to provide about the topic. The interviewer collects demographic information and proceeds to thank the interviewee for their time and energy, closing the interview in a thoughtful manner.

Measures

My four initial open-ended questions include:

(1) What ways do you commonly travel around your neighborhood?
(2) Do you feel socially integrated with your physical neighborhood, for example, do you regularly run into people you know while out and about?
(3) Can you describe the places where you typically interact with other community members? What are those spaces like?
(4) Do you use digital communication (texting, social media, group chats) to stay connected with people in your local community?

These questions map onto my research question as follows. The first question addresses physical mobility, understanding how informants get around and whether their transportation choices are autonomous or constrained by infrastructure. This establishes the context in which social interaction may or may not occur. The second question measures integration into community storytelling networks, including interpersonal relationships, community organizations, and local media, the key components of an integrated storytelling network (Kim & Ball-Rokeach, 2006). The third question explores place attachment and the nature of social settings, investigating whether interactions happen in communal third spaces or primarily in transactional, commercial spaces. The fourth question examines whether digital communication serves as a compensatory mechanism when in-person interaction opportunities are limited (Nah et al., 2021).

A follow-up to the first question asks whether the informant feels their mode of transportation is a fully autonomous choice or one shaped by their environment. This is important because individuals who feel compelled to drive due to a lack of alternatives may have fewer opportunities for spontaneous social interaction. A follow-up to the third question asks what types of activities occur in the spaces where they run into others, and whether those encounters feel purposeful or incidental. This helps distinguish between infrastructure that facilitates community connection and infrastructure that only permits it as a byproduct of necessary errands. The fourth question's follow-up asks whether the informant engages with local individuals or communities through digital means, and whether those connections also exist in person. This probes the idea that limited physical mobility may drive residents to form community ties through digital platforms, potentially creating different pathways to civic engagement and sense of community (Aguiléra et al., 2012; Nah et al., 2021).

Ethical Considerations

First, because this study uses a convenience sample drawn from the researcher's own network, the data may be biased and not representative of the broader population. I will address this by being transparent about the sample's limitations in my findings rather than claiming generalizability. Second, the interview method requires building trust while also being honest about the research purpose and recording. I will obtain informed consent before each interview, explain how the data will be used, and maintain a conversational, non-coercive tone throughout.

Expected Findings

State Expected Findings

As a reminder, my research question has two parts: (a) To what extent do car-dependent communities inhibit residents' ability to access their social networks? (b) To what extent do car-dependent environments influence whether communication occurs face-to-face or through mediated channels? I expect individuals who rely primarily on cars for transportation to report lower trust in their community members than those with access to diverse transportation options. I expect this lower trust to stem from a weaker sense of place and a lack of physical third spaces for community gathering. Third places provide a situational context where residents can gather publicly and engage with their neighborhood, increasing the density of community networks. Author (year) notes that prioritizing automobility degrades individuals' sense of place. This degraded sense of place, combined with a scarcity of communal physical spaces, will prompt residents to adopt a coping mechanism, turning to digital spaces as an alternative. These digital spaces can provide a sense of place, but that sense of place is built through the social activities that occur there rather than through physical co-presence.

Anticipate the Data

One of my initial questions measures the availability of opportunities for community interaction, with follow-ups about the context of those interactions, place, time, and activity. I expect most interviewees in car-dependent communities to report that they socialize with neighbors mainly while running errands at commercial locations like grocery stores or laundromats. The problem is that these places are designed for commerce, not social lingering. The big-box architecture and sprawling parking lots reinforce a negatively associated sense of place and discourage pedestrian-friendly interaction. The social norm of these establishments pressures people to keep conversations short, the space is meant to move shoppers in and out efficiently. This limits the amount of information sharing and storytelling that can occur. If the storytelling mechanism that builds connection to one's neighborhood is constrained by a lack of suitable physical spaces, this would confirm my hypothesis that individuals in car-dependent communities experience less network density. Repeated responses like this would form a theme of limited storytelling, resulting in sparse network density.

A disconfirming response would describe ample opportunities for spontaneous social interaction, even within a car-dependent community. These interactions would be regular and would deepen or extend social bonds. Crucially, they would occur in contexts without the environmental pressure to cut conversations short. Repeated responses like this would form a theme of open storytelling networks, resulting in denser network density.

Codes and decision rules:

Mode of transportation: Responses describing primary travel method (car, walk, bike, bus, train) will be coded as car-dependent (reliance on personal vehicle) or non-car-dependent (walking, transit, biking). Decision rule: if the interviewee states they drive for the majority of local trips, code as car-dependent.

Type of social space: Locations where social interaction occurs will be coded as first place (home), second place (work/school), third place (park, library, community center, no monetary barrier required), or commercial space (grocery store, laundromat, retail). Decision rule: if the interaction occurs in a setting where the primary purpose is commerce rather than socializing, code as commercial space.

Quality of interaction: The emotional outcome of social encounters will be coded as rushed (interviewee felt time pressure, conversation felt cut short) or deep (interviewee felt able to linger, conversation felt meaningful). Decision rule: if the interviewee describes feeling the need to keep the conversation brief due to the setting, code as rushed.

Interpret Your Findings

In the case that the data confirms that car-dependent infrastructure hinders community social interaction and produces sparser networks, this finding would extend Communication Infrastructure Theory (Ball-Rokeach et al., 2001). Rather than car dependency simply influencing communication outcomes, the finding would support the claim that mobility context moderates communication outcomes, including civic engagement, network density, and place attachment. The mobility context (how and why individuals move through their community) would be understood as a type of communication action context, alongside the geographic and economic boundaries CIT has traditionally used.

For practice, this finding would inform urban planners seeking a more holistic approach to transportation infrastructure. Understanding that car-centric design affects residents' social networks and place attachment gives planners evidence for prioritizing pedestrian-friendly design and third spaces. This matters for cities trying to attract population growth and support democratic engagement, since third spaces and the ability to interact with neighbors are essential to a functioning public square.

If the data show that car-dependent infrastructure has little to no impact on social opportunities and network density, a likely alternative explanation is that digital spaces are effectively compensating for the lack of traditional physical community spaces. Residents may have adopted digital communication as a coping mechanism, weaving it into their lifestyles to maintain social connection despite physical disconnection. This would raise questions about whether trust and empathy carry over into digital networks or fail to develop in the same way.

For research, disconfirmation would suggest that mobility acts as a mediator rather than a moderator of communication outcomes, it plays a role, but not a determinative one. For practice, this would inform stakeholders (such as local businesses or marketing professionals) that the digital landscape functions as a meaningful alternative space for neighborhood storytelling. Investment in digital community-building may be as important as investment in physical third spaces.

Generative AI Use Statement

No generative AI tools were used in the creation of this assignment.

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Measurement Instrument (Appendix)

Measuring physical mobility:

What ways do you commonly travel around your neighborhood?
Is your method of getting around a completely autonomous choice or one constructed by your environment? To what extent do you feel you have complete freedom to travel in your community?

Measuring storytelling network integration:

Do you feel socially integrated with your physical neighborhood? Do you regularly run into your peers while visiting locations in your neighborhood?
Do you hold many one-on-one (interpersonal) relationships?
Are you involved with any organizations or groups within your community?
Are you engaged with any forms of local media?
Do you participate in any forms of civic engagement?

Measuring social capital and place attachment:

Do you feel a high level of trust with your community? (e.g., Would you be able to ask to borrow a tool or ingredient from your neighbor? How many neighbors would you feel comfortable asking?)
Do you feel safe when you are in your community?
What types of activities are being done at the places in which you are running into others? Where do you commonly run into others?
Please describe the social setting in which you commonly run into other community members.
What types of spaces do you normally utilize as a social setting? Is this on purpose or incidental?
Do you feel attached to your physical residential neighborhood?
Do you foster a sense of community?
What types of emotions, attitudes, or opinions come up when you think about your residential neighborhood?

Measuring digital reliance as a compensatory mechanism:

Do you use any digital means of communication? (e.g., text messaging, group chats, social media such as Facebook, Instagram, or Reddit?)
When you engage in online communication, do you engage with other individuals or communities who are local? Do you engage with these groups both in person and online?
Do you feel like the infrastructure and lack of transportation options makes it inconvenient to socialize?

Demographic information (optional): Age, gender, ethnicity, education level, sexual orientation, occupation

Hypotheses

H1: Higher levels of integrated connection to community storytelling networks (ICSN) will be positively associated with individuals' sense of belonging in their local community.

H2: Individuals with higher physical mobility will report greater engagement in interpersonal storytelling.
H3: Individuals with higher physical mobility will report greater engagement with community organization storytelling.
H4: Individuals with higher physical mobility will have greater access to or engagement with local media storytelling.
H5: Individuals with lower physical mobility will show greater reliance on digital media/apps.

RQ1: Does physical mobility condition the relationship between storytelling networks and neighborhood belonging?

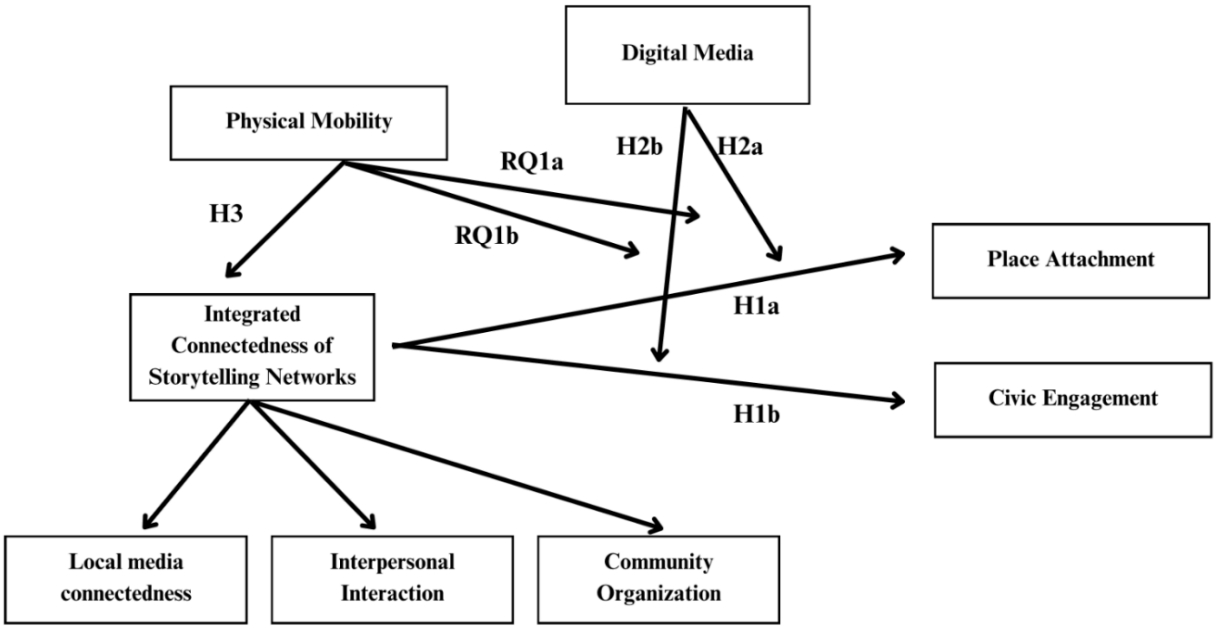


Figure 1: The image above displays the relationships between the measures of Physical Mobility, Integrated Connectedness of Storytelling Networks, Digital Media, Place Attachment and Civic Engagement.